

The Impact of Fan Creations in the Video Game

Industry

Introduction

In the video game industry, those who play the games have always held a desire to produce their own content. The place this content has in relation to official products has evolved with the industry. Regarding media in general, J. Rosen (2006) remarks that just as consequential as the existing system of the big media producers feeding the audience is the audience members feeding each other. The audience and the media powers are now on equal terms, following a significant “shift in power”. For Rosen this is a result of the audience’s desire for media to be better or more accessible; they desire it on their own terms. He states that once the opportunity arises, it is inevitable that the audience will seize control of the media.

When the audience transcends just consuming the media, coming to engage with it through more creative means, it has entered “participatory culture”. Jenkins (2007) details five properties of participatory culture: it is easy to participate, participating is encouraged, knowledge is shared, participation is valued, and there is a sense of community. Jenkins believes participatory culture to be important as an expression of our innate creativity, as individuals within the audience.

This essay explores the extent to which power has shifted within the games industry specifically, how it has brought about a participatory culture,

and how this changing culture has been accommodated by the media producers.

Modding

In the games industry, the most obvious example of the audience taking control of the media is with “modding”. Sotamaa (2010) explains that “modding” is short for “modifying”, and it is when a player modifies an existing game. A “modder” is someone who creates “mods” (modifications of a game); Postigo (2007) also calls them “fan-programmers” (p.301), although not all modding involves programming. Postigo notes that mods may take the form of alterations of mechanics, new levels or “maps”, changes in visual assets, and large-scale overhauls. The value of modding as participatory culture has varied throughout its history, given initial barriers to entry, and an inconsistent relationship with developers.

G. Vorhees (2023) points to *Lode Runner* (Smith, D. 1983) as the first game to include a level editor with which all users could make their own content, allowing them to shape new experiences beyond the core content of the game. This indicates that very early on, developers were aware of players’ desire to take control of their experience. *Lode Runner* is a very simple 2D platformer, and as games grew in complexity throughout the 80’s the scope for creativity grew.

It was with the emergence of first-person shooters in the 1990’s that Nielson (2020) claims the modding community was truly born. He describes the efforts of ambitious players to mod *Wolfenstein 3D* (id Software, 1992), with an online community growing through the sharing of various

modifications. In the absence of development tools, as was the case with *Wolfenstein*, modders must reverse-engineer the game – which requires immense knowledge and skill (Curtis et al, 2022). This barrier to entry does not immediately fit with Jenkins’ definition of participatory culture; but modders with the necessary ability creating their own tools for the use of others not only remedies this but fits in with the passing-on of knowledge symptomatic of participatory culture. And while modding technically violates certain terms of use, Curtis (et al) explains that many developers are open to modding given the community around it enhances interest in the game, with Postigo noting this extends to economic gain for the developers.

Though importantly, while creating maps for *Wolfenstein* can be considered constructive, Guajardo (2023) notes the distinction between “beneficial” mods and those which are more likely to be considered “hacking”, such as cheating in an online game, and these mods are less tolerated by other players and the developers. Where on the one hand mods can bring about a positive participatory culture, a misuse of this power results in a hostility between modders and non-modders – particularly in online games where all players are expected to be on a level playing field (Curtis et al). This essay focuses on singleplayer games, where players can modify their experience without affecting the experience of others, but given the public circulation of mods, ethical issues still arise with the content people choose to share. For example, developers may not want excessively violent mods, or those considered “not safe for work”, associated with their game. But the majority of mods are considered positive as they grant the player the freedom to engage with the game on their own terms.

Realising the advantages mods offered their games, Nielson explains that for their next title id Software stored the game's data separately from the program to allow aspiring modders to more easily create mods, and do so without affecting the program itself, thus also making it easier for mods to be shared. It is with this game, *DOOM* (id Software, 1993), that Vorhees claims video game modding became widespread. He includes that, after modders produced their own level editors for public use, eventually id Software released the source code to give players complete modding freedom. Here modding can be considered to go from a niche and specialist interest to a cornerstone of video game participatory culture.

Another first-person shooter that had a great impact on the modding scene was *Half-Life* (Valve, 1998) – which incidentally used *GoldSrc* (Valve, 1998), a modification of the engine of id Software's *Quake* (id Software, 1996), which itself was an advancement upon the engine to *DOOM*. (GameSpot UK, 1999). Thus *Half-Life* can be considered a sort of exceptional child of the *DOOM* modding scene. Nielson claims “Counter-Strike”, a mod for *Half-Life*, to be the most successful mod of all time. *Counter-Strike* (Valve, 2000), by the developers of *Half-Life*, was since released as its own game. Au (2002) pointed to “Day of Defeat”, another multiplayer mod for *Half-Life* that was released by Valve as an official add-on, as the point of no return, from which developers and the community would always work hand-in-hand. Au reports Newell of Valve, who describes the aim of Valve's “Steam” to give a platform to modders. The comparative activity of “Day of Defeat” compared to contemporary WWII-inspired first-person shooters by big developers, namely *Medal of Honour* (DreamWorks Interactive, 1999) and

Return to Castle Wolfenstein (Gray Matter Studios, 2001), is interpreted by Au to indicate developers must rely on the community to succeed over their competition. Au wondered whether developers would continue to work in collaboration with modders for the benefit of the community, or commit “cannibalism” by taking advantage of them. The evolution of Bethesda’s *The Elder Scrolls* series may reveal how the relationship between developers and modders has continued since 2002.

Recognising the modding potential of their games, much like id Software before them, Bethesda have always encouraged the community in this practice, releasing development kits for their games. Postigo takes this as evidence of developers understanding a significant benefit of mods: that they extend the “life of a game” (p.302), by which he means the period in which the game’s community is still active. Physical copies of *The Elder Scrolls III: Morrowind* (Bethesda Game Studios, 2002) for the PC came with a second disc carrying The Elder Scrolls Construction Set – a powerful tool with which users could modify any part of the game and produce an ESP file that could be loaded with the game as a plugin. The ease at which players could mod the game explains why the *Morrowind* modding scene remains incredibly active over two decades later.

The increased longevity of *Morrowind* can be understood in terms of the various mods being released. First, long-time fans of the game always have a reason to return, given the inexhaustible stream of new content: new quests, items, characters, locations, and so on. Tamriel Rebuilt, an epic collaborative effort that brings the mainland of the Morrowind province to the game, is cited by Hall (2018) as enough reason to reinstall the game. And second, the

decades-old game, which could be considered archaic in its unmodified form, is made ever-relevant through graphical overhauls, including shaders, new models, and high-resolution textures, in addition to fan-made patches fixing bugs left unresolved by the original developers. This makes the game more inviting to newer players.

Morrowind set the standard for the modding of Bethesda's grand role-playing series, with newer entries being even more popular with modders. And it is with newer entries that Bethesda's relationship with modders changes. On Nexus Mods (www.NexusMods.com [Accessed 27th April 2024]), the most popular website for downloading mods, *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim* (Bethesda Game Studios, 2011) is the game with the second-highest number of mod downloads, at an astonishing 1.9 billion. It is superseded only by its remaster, *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim – Special Edition* (Bethesda Game Studios, 2016), which itself has had 4.3 billion downloads of mods from the website. Though the core game as it was released offers an abundance of content, it is easy to say the game owes its longevity to its modding scene – a fact which was anticipated by Bethesda before the release of the game, informing many decisions they would make.

Following the example of *Morrowind*, Bethesda released the Creation Kit for *Skyrim*, a few months after the release of the game. Far apart from the prior decades when ambitious modders would need to work within their own community, developing their own tools and sharing techniques – now their hands were held every step of the way, by the developers of the game no less. Bethesda even uploaded tutorial videos for their Creation Kit and maintained

an official Wiki. (The Elder Scrolls Wiki). The subsequent re-release of *Skyrim* would be even more accommodating.

Modding has traditionally been an activity limited to PC players. But the 2016 *Skyrim -- Special Edition* offered users on consoles the opportunity to download mods made by other players – a feature of Bethesda’s recent *Fallout 4* (Bethesda Game Studios, 2015) (Skrebels, 2016). So important did they see mods to the game, that Bethesda even battled with Sony to allow mods on PlayStation 4 after initial disapproval (Bethesda, 2016), as a compromise, given players would be limited to the assets of the original game (Bethesda, 2016). Not only did bringing mods to console extend the reach of player-developed content to players previously limited to the base game, but allowing them to be downloaded from the main menu negated the need for third-party launchers and accounts, thus making it easier and more attractive to players without prior modding experience. This official incorporation of modding is a step towards the collaboration that Au had envisioned, and a participatory culture that is easy to engage with, and engagement is encouraged.

The introduction of the “Creation Club”, however, was a controversial development as it strayed far from the player-driven traditions of modding. Already, Bethesda had faced backlash after trying to monetise mods on Valve’s Steam Workshop, with Valve removing the feature days after its implementation (McWhertor, 2015), so another venture into paid mods in 2017 was a surprise. Valve’s intentions behind paid mods can be understood: it financially supports the efforts of the modder, enabling them to work full-time on their projects. The hope was that this would result in a greater output of grand and highly refined mods. (McWhertor, 2015). But the community

was largely unhappy about the idea of being asked to pay for what, for a long time, had been free. The fact that money is not a motivation is important to the modding community as mods are traditionally creations of passion. Following this first backlash, Bethesda were insistent that the Creation Club is not “paid mods” (Livingston, 2017), the difference being that Bethesda themselves contracted members of the Creation Club, resulting in a certain expectation of quality, while mods would continue to be free. Creation Club content can therefore be thought more along the lines of community-developed DLC (“DownLoadable Content” – the term used for additional game content released by the publisher, usually for a price (Wells, 2020)). The Creation Club has since been rebranded as the Creations scheme, in which players can register to become “Verified Creators”, the aim being to make it easier to release monetised creations. But this comes at the compromise of the quality guaranteed by Creation Club content: Verified Creations are no longer expected to be lore-friendly, or to support multiple languages, for example. (Bethesda). Perhaps here there are the signs of the “cannibalism” Au had warned about, where developers profit from the community without respecting it.

The attempt by Bethesda to have the developer-side and community-side of creation interact brings to light certain differences. With anything produced by the main developer there is an expectation that it will be consistent with the rest of the game, both in quality and theme. Modders, however, are unrestricted: they are awarded a freedom, without responsibility to meet certain expectations. Attempting to monetise, or verify, anything by the community requires finding a compromise between the creator’s freedom

and the quality expected by the fans. Returning to Rosen's idea, the media producer is determining the terms on which we consume our media, while the audience (in this case, the modders) wish to escape that. Is Bethesda trying to restrain modders, or empower them? The release of *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim Anniversary Edition* (Bethesda Game Studios, 2021) as *Skyrim – Special Edition* with the addition of all previously-released Creation Club content highlights that Bethesda really thinks of community-made content as a massive component of *Skyrim* and its legacy. The developers valuing player-made content is important in Jenkins' definition of participatory culture. And while the Verified Creator scheme continues to support modders in their efforts, the production of free mods is still actively encouraged, and third-party sources like Nexus Mods remain central to the community.

Fan Games

Beyond mods, perhaps the most ambitious form of audience-created content in the video game industry is "fan games", the term used for an unofficial game created of an existing intellectual property (IP) by a fan of that IP. But given they compete with the primary media of the IP, rather than enhancing the player's experience of them (as with mods), fan games have a less cordial relationship with developers than other fan creations, so could be considered less valuable in participatory culture. While mods generally make the developer's game more attractive and increase its longevity, fan games could divert fans' attention from official products. This is especially noticeable with fan remakes of older games. For example, a work-in-progress fan-remake of *Resident Evil* (Capcom, 1996), with improved graphics and

modernised gameplay, was shut down by Capcom (Garcia, 2022). Developers do not want to lose sales of their own games to fan remakes. Also, with classic games, the developers often have their own plans to remake them, and do not wish to compete with a free fan-made equivalent.

A surprising exception when it comes to fan games is Sega, who supports the making of fan games of some of their IPs. Fan developer Christian Whitehead developed a proof-of-concept for a wide-screen mobile remaster of *Sonic CD* (Sega, 1993) in his own Retro Engine (Hodapp, 2009). Sega hired him and released the project officially (Parkin, 2011). While mobile ports already existed of the first two games, following the success of the *Sonic CD* remaster, Whitehead helped Sega produce improved mobile remasters of *Sonic the Hedgehog* (Sonic Team, 1991) and *Sonic the Hedgehog 2* (Sega Technical Institute, 1992) in his Retro Engine (Mawson, 2015). Sega capitalised on the passion of its fanbase in order to release its classic titles in much-improved states to the modern audience. Whitehead even went on to develop the official, original game *Sonic Mania* (Christian Whitehead, 2017) – an appraised successor to the classic games, which would not exist were it not for Sega’s willingness to cooperate with its fans.

Newman (2005) notes that a lack of necessary skills is a reason for the infrequency of entire fan-created games when compared with other fan-created media such as art or fiction. So it does not fit with Jenkins’ expectation of participatory culture to be accessible. Yet in the almost 20 years since Newman’s article we have seen great advances in accessible means of games development. These games can now also be of closer quality to those released officially. *Unity* (Unity Technologies, 2005) has been immensely popular with

solo developers given it is free for personal use and easy to use with an ever-growing community and extensive tutorials. Ian Morris (known online by “ChaosX”) has worked, largely alone, to recreate the infamously ill-received 2006 *Sonic the Hedgehog* (Sonic Team, 2006) in its entirety (Summers, 2019). The majority of the game is now complete and playable, and is generally regarded as an immense improvement upon the original game. It is incredible that with the tools available today, one person can create a large-scale 3D game. It is also important to note the care fans will give to a game neglected by its original developer. Fans of the *Sonic the Hedgehog* franchise are now coming to appreciate a game initially very poorly received because of the passion one had to see it fully realised. Time will tell if, like with Whitehead and the *Sonic CD* remaster, Sega hires Morris for official projects, or allows the appreciation of this neglected game to inform some of their future releases.

Fan games are interesting as they exist not, like mods, to add desired features to existing games, but instead to fill in perceived gaps within the game franchise. This could be, as discussed, by remaking a game in need of a revival. It could also be the creation of a more original game that features what the fans want from an original game. So fan games could be considered one of the most powerful forms of audience expression as it shows exactly what the fans want – and more importantly, whether what they want is actually feasible. This information is invaluable to developers, whose direction too often differs from the desires of the fans.

Conclusion

After exploring two elements of video game participatory culture, we have a picture of the “shift in power” that has occurred. Developers have come to realise that it is in their interest to promote the creative endeavours of their fans. The lifetime of their product can be prolonged indefinitely through player-made modifications. While fan games do not enhance the experience of a particular officially released game, they do increase interest in the franchise as a whole, as well as acting as a voice for the fans that echoes the fans’ view of the franchise.

With so much audience creativity, it is necessary for the developers to acknowledge it. Increasingly, recognising its advantages, developers are coming to embrace it, but care needs to be taken in this relationship. It will only continue to be healthy and productive as long as there is the correct balance between support from the developers, and freedom for the audience. A beneficial participatory culture can only exist with the correct relationship between developers and fans.

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